

THE FLAGSHIP FREE RESOURCE

THE STUDIO AUDIT

A positioning, offer, and inquiry-process review for the independent creative practice.

Use this audit once a quarter. Drift is normal. Unchecked drift becomes a gap.
Six areas · 69 prompts · one action-priority worksheet.

INTRODUCTION

00

HOW TO USE THIS AUDIT

The Studio Audit is a structured review of the six areas where independent creative practices most often drift: positioning, website clarity, offer clarity, inquiry process, pricing communication, and an action-priority worksheet. It is the diagnostic you would do for a friend's practice on a long walk, written down.

Use it once a quarter. Block out an afternoon. Read each prompt aloud. Write your answer in the space provided — not in your head. The audit only works if you externalize. A vague answer is data; a blank answer is the most useful kind of data.

Drift is normal. It is the cost of doing client work instead of working on the practice. The audit is how you catch it before it becomes a gap.

The six sections move from abstract (positioning) to concrete (pricing communication) and end with a single action-priority worksheet. Do them in order. Each section takes ten to twenty minutes. Do not skip the worksheet at the end — it is the only page that asks you to commit.

THE SIX AREAS

01 Positioning

Who you serve, what changes for them, who you decline.

02 Website clarity

Whether a stranger could explain what you do after one minute.

03 Offer clarity

Whether each offer names its deliverable, inputs, and disqualifiers.

04 Inquiry process

Whether inquiries are acknowledged, qualified, and answered in writing.

05 Pricing communication

Whether the price is a stated number with a written scope — not a feeling.

06 Action-priority worksheet

Where you commit to the next move.

01

POSITIONING SELF-ASSESSMENT

Answer each question in one or two sentences. If you cannot answer in two sentences, you do not yet have the answer. That is the point of the question.

01 In one sentence, who do you serve and what change do you produce for them?

02 Could a non-specialist name three buyers who would not be a fit? If not, your positioning is too broad.

03 When you describe what you do, do you lead with your discipline ("I'm a designer") or with the outcome you produce?

04 Do you have a written positioning sentence that you revisit at least once a quarter?

05 Name your three best past clients. What do they have in common — discipline, scale, stage, problem?

06 Name your three most difficult past clients. What do they have in common?

07 If a stranger read your website for sixty seconds, who would they say you serve?

08 Are there services listed on your site that you no longer want to deliver? List them.

09 Are there buyers you would politely decline today that you would have taken a year ago?

10 Does your positioning match the work your last three clients actually bought — or the work you wish they had bought?

11 Are you competing on category (what you do) or on outcome (what changes for the buyer)?

12 What is one sentence you could remove from your website today that would make the rest sharper?

02

WEBSITE CLARITY CHECKLIST

Read each item aloud against your live site. Check the box only if it is true today — not if it was true last quarter, not if it is on your to-do list.

- ☐ The homepage states who you serve in the first scroll.
- ☐ The homepage states what changes for the buyer, not only what you do.
- ☐ Services are listed in priority order — not alphabetically and not randomly.
- ☐ Each service has a one-sentence description a non-specialist could repeat back.
- ☐ There is a visible path to start a conversation (a contact or inquiry page).
- ☐ The inquiry page tells the buyer what information to include.
- ☐ Sample work is captioned with the buyer's outcome, not only the deliverable.
- ☐ Pricing language (or the absence of pricing language) is consistent across pages.
- ☐ Testimonials are attributed with buyer role and discipline — not only initials.
- ☐ The About page describes how you work, not only who you are.
- ☐ No service is listed that you would not currently deliver.
- ☐ There is no claim on the site that you could not defend in a discovery call.
- ☐ The site loads without errors on a phone.
- ☐ The footer includes a working contact method.
- ☐ A first-time visitor could explain what you do after one minute on the site.

03

OFFER CLARITY REVIEW

For each offer on your current menu, answer these eight questions. If you have more than three offers and cannot answer the questions for all of them, that is itself an answer.

01 For each offer, can you name the specific deliverable the buyer receives at the end?

02 For each offer, can you name the inputs the buyer must provide for the work to succeed?

03 For each offer, can you name the buyer who is a poor fit and should be declined?

04 For each offer, can you name the typical duration in weeks — not in "phases"?

05 For each offer, can you state the price without recalculating it each time?

06 Is the revision boundary written down (number of rounds, what counts as a revision)?

07 Is the next step after delivery defined — handoff, support window, anything else?

08 Are there offers currently on your menu that you would not deliver to your best client?

04

INQUIRY PROCESS REVIEW

Inquiry process is where most practices lose good buyers. The buyer who emails you on a Tuesday has also emailed two other people. Speed and clarity are not optional.

- ☐ Inquiries are acknowledged within one business day — even if only to say "I'll respond fully by Friday."
- ☐ The acknowledgment tells the buyer what happens next and when.
- ☐ Inquiries are qualified against a written client profile before a call is booked.
- ☐ Discovery calls have a written agenda that is shared in advance.
- ☐ Discovery calls end with a stated next step: proposal, decline, or follow-up.
- ☐ Notes from the discovery call are written down within twenty-four hours.
- ☐ Proposals are sent within five business days of the call.
- ☐ Proposals are sent only after the scope has been confirmed in writing.
- ☐ Declined inquiries receive a polite, written response — not silence.
- ☐ The pipeline (inquiries !' calls !' proposals !' decisions) is reviewed weekly.

05

PRICING COMMUNICATION CHECKLIST

How you talk about price shapes how the buyer receives it. Most pricing disputes are not about the number — they are about the conversation that came before the number.

- ☐ The buyer is told the price before the proposal is sent — not inside it for the first time.
- ☐ The price is stated as a number, not a range and not "starting at."
- ☐ The price includes a written scope. There is no "and any related tasks."
- ☐ The proposal names what is excluded, not only what is included.
- ☐ Payment terms (deposit, milestones, final) are written in the proposal.
- ☐ The proposal states when payment is due — not only how much.
- ☐ Late-payment consequences are stated in the proposal, not added after the fact.
- ☐ Discounts, when offered, are framed as a deliberate choice with a stated reason.
- ☐ The buyer is not asked "what is your budget?" without a stated reason for asking.
- ☐ The proposal does not include optional add-ons the buyer did not request.
- ☐ The price is not negotiated against itself in the buyer's absence.
- ☐ The pricing conversation is documented in writing after the call.

06

ACTION-PRIORITY WORKSHEET

From the five review sections above, list what is drifting. For each item, mark priority 1 (do this week), 2 (this month), or 3 (this quarter). Then write one next action — not a goal, an action. The next action is the smallest concrete step that moves the item forward.

AREA	WHAT'S DRIFTING	PRIORITY (1–3)	NEXT ACTION
01			
02			
03			
04			
05			
06			
07			
08			

AFTER THE AUDIT

07

HOW TO READ YOUR ANSWERS

Once you have written your answers, look for three patterns. They are more useful than any individual answer.

PATTERN ONE — BLANK ANSWERS

Any question you could not answer is the most useful data from the audit. A blank answer marks a place where the practice is running on assumption rather than decision. Treat blanks as priority-one items.

PATTERN TWO — CONTRADICTIONS

If your answer to a positioning question says you serve early-stage founders and your answer to an offer question says your typical engagement is twelve weeks at a fixed price, you have a contradiction. Contradictions are where drift hides. Name them.

PATTERN THREE — REPEATS

If the same phrase appears in three answers — "I keep meaning to write that down" — that is the next action. Not next quarter. This week.

The audit does not produce a strategy. It produces a list. The list is the strategy.

CADENCE

08

HOW OFTEN, AND WHAT TO DO WITH IT

Run the audit four times a year. Pick a cadence you will actually keep — the first Friday of every quarter, the Monday after a project ships, the day before your birthday. Put it on the calendar. The audit takes an afternoon. It pays for itself the first time it catches a pricing clause you would otherwise have left out of a proposal.

After the audit, write one paragraph to yourself: what changed since last quarter, what is the single priority for this quarter, and what is the next action on that priority. Keep these paragraphs. After a year, read them in order. You will see your own drift.

WHAT THE AUDIT IS NOT

It is not a strategy document. It does not tell you what to do — it tells you where you have not yet decided. It is not a benchmark against other practices. It is not a substitute for talking to your three best clients about what they actually needed. And it is not a one-time exercise. Drift comes back. The audit comes back too.

A NOTE FROM THE STUDIO

09

WHY WE MADE THIS

We made the audit because we kept watching good creatives lose good buyers for reasons that had nothing to do with the quality of the work. The work was excellent. The positioning had drifted. The offer was unclear. The inquiry went unanswered for four days. The proposal arrived without an exclusions list and the scope grew. None of these are creative failures. They are operational ones.

The audit is the lightest possible structure that catches them. It does not replace a course, a coach, or a community. It replaces the nothing that most practices have in their place.

The work is what makes the practice good. The practice is what makes the work possible. The audit is how you keep the practice in working order.

If you find the audit useful, the next step is The Independent Practice — the six-module course that builds the frameworks the audit points at. If the audit is enough for now, that is also fine. Come back in ninety days.

IF THIS WAS USEFUL

10

WHERE TO GO NEXT

The audit is diagnostic. The resources below are prescriptive — they tell you how to fix what the audit finds.

The Proposal Checklist

FREE · 3 PAGES

If section four or five of the audit turned up gaps, this is the fix. The seven sections a clear proposal needs and the clauses that prevent most disputes.

The Pricing Starter

FREE · 5 PAGES

If section five of the audit turned up a price that is a feeling, this is the fix. A first pricing model — capacity, cost floor, scope multiplier, target price.

The Independent Practice

COURSE · \$349

If the audit turned up blanks in section one or three, the course is the long-form fix. Six modules on positioning, offers, inquiry process, pricing, proposals, and delivery.

The Proposal System

TOOLKIT · \$79

If section four of the audit turned up a proposal that arrives late and without an exclusions list, this is the toolkit. Templates, worksheets, clauses.

The Pricing Workbook

WORKBOOK · \$49

If the Pricing Starter was not enough — three worked scenarios, a discount-decision checklist, a per-offer pricing model.

The Client Brief Kit

KIT · \$39

If section four of the audit turned up discovery calls without agendas, this is the kit. Discovery questionnaire, project brief template, handoff checklist.

CLOSING NOTE

11

A CLOSING NOTE

You do not need to fix everything the audit finds. You need to fix one thing this week, one thing this month, and one thing this quarter. The rest can wait. The rest is what the next audit is for.

If you are tempted to skip the action-priority worksheet at the back, that is the signal to do it. The worksheet is the page where the audit stops being a review and becomes a decision. Everything before it is diagnosis. The worksheet is the prescription.

A practice is not a thing you have. It is a thing you tend. The audit is the act of tending.

Thank you for taking the time. If this was useful, send it to one person you know who runs a practice of their own. If it was not, tell us why. We revise the audit between volumes — the prompts are not fixed. They are the questions we have found most useful, most often, for the practices we have worked with.

DISCLOSURE

12

DEMO DISCLOSURE

Margin / Form is a fictional creator business. This is a demonstration resource. The frameworks, prompts, and worksheets are real and usable — they were written to be used. The business itself is a portfolio demonstration of how an independent creative-education practice might publish, sell, and support its work.

No purchase is possible from this site. No email you enter will be added to a real list. No proposal sent from the templates in the shop will be received by a real buyer. The audit you just completed, however, is yours. Use it.

Margin / Form is a fictional creator business. This is a demonstration resource.